Something else can get stolen, and no one would even know.

What's the Accession Register story? On May 6, Dr J.R. Bhagat, the museum's curator in-charge, wrote it down for the state's director, archaeology and museums. He had been carrying out physical verification of artifacts every year, his letter said, affirming that rare artifacts are kept in a room with a double lock system. The Accession Register, too, is kept there. During a visit of President Droupadi Murmu in 2023, he wrote, this room was opened to show her the Sirpur bronzes—including the 'Manjushree' that has travelled to various Festivals of India.

Takeaways

- **The statue is found and returned by a Manhattan District Attorney**
- **Termites claim the register in a Raipur museum that recorded its presence**

That day, wrote Bhagat, the register was intact. But on May 6, when he opened the room to prepare for handing over charge on his upcoming superannuation, Accession Registers numbers 2 to 6 were found eaten up by termites. Number 1 seems to have survived safely. Perhaps some version of the registers, Bhagat suggested, are in Bhopal—from before the state division—and could be sought to make fresh copies. It's not clear whether the Madhya Pradesh government has responded to Chhattisgarh's request, or whether a request has been made at all. Nor is it clear that the mandated physical verification was happening annually. Termites usually take a long time to destroy something. By now, they seem to have got at India's memory of itself. ■

HOLDING OUT
(In dark coat) AAP MLA Chaitar Vasava at a roadshow, Apr. 10

@Chaitar_Vasava/X



▶ GUJARAT

The Adivasi Who Could Not Be Defeated

National parties, including the BJP, may want to coopt him. For now, Chaitar Vasava stands uniquely aloof in Gujarat

By **Jumana Shah**

IN GUJARAT'S LOCAL BODY ELECTIONS, the BJP swept 33 of 34 district panchayats. The one that held out, Narmada, was the handiwork of a 36-year-old Adivasi MLA. He campaigned on bail, was debarred from his own constituency, and had to field two wives to canvass in his place—with 19 FIRs to his name, he was practically left dodging the law, in a manner of speaking. But his aura as a maverick rebel worked for Chaitar Vasava, the Aam Aadmi Party's legislative party leader. He delivered 15 out of Narmada's 22 district panchayat seats, and four of its six taluka panchayats. Verdict: Vasava is a figure the BJP cannot neutralise and the Congress cannot reclaim.

In an election dominated by the BJP at almost every tier, central-eastern Gujarat's Narmada district stood out. The victor is arguably Gujarat's most combustible politician today. Most of the FIRs Vasava has gathered since 2022—for rioting, assault, extortion, attempt to murder, firing in the air et al—relate to political confrontations or clashes with the administration over the Forest Rights Act. That's only added to his lustre as the new rising star in the tribal belt.

Even if not in volumes that threaten the status quo fully, Adivasi politics keeps throwing up a kind of independent-minded politics, holding out in an aspect of sullen alienation, that makes both the BJP and Congress distinctly uneasy. Their comfort level increases only with cooption, as seen with their designs on Gujarat's tribal elder, Chaitar's one-time mentor Chhotubhai Vasava, founder of the Bharatiya Tribal Party (BTP) and advocate of a separate Bhilistan.

THE IRON BENDS HERE

Now Gujarat has its next Vasava. The BJP may have won about 95 per cent of the 9,682 local body seats it contested in April, and will run all 17 municipal corporations, 79 of 84 municipalities and 34 of 35 district panchayats. Yet, the loss of Narmada carries extra